

SCIENCE OF READING REVIEW: UNIVERSITY OF ARKANSAS - FORT SMITH

TRADITIONAL

On-Site Review: Date not reported

WHAT'S IN THIS REPORT?

This report uses evidence from an on-site review to examine how an educator preparation program prepares candidates to teach reading using scientific reading instruction, as Arkansas requires of every approved program. It is meant to inform a continuous improvement process that takes educator preparation programs closer to the goals needed to serve Arkansas's students.

The on-site reviews are carried out by Teacher Prep Inspection-US (TPI-US), an external review organization. TPI-US teams inspect coursework and course materials, observe instruction and clinical practice, review program data, and hold focus groups with candidates, faculty, mentor teachers, and school partners. Division of Elementary and Secondary Education staff participate in the review.

TPI-US rates the program in the three review areas of the Arkansas Literacy Review Framework:

- Review Area 1, "Quality of Literacy Coursework," is rated from course materials, syllabi, assignments, and observations of instruction.
- Review Area 2, "Quality of Field-Based Experiences," is rated from placement records, observation and feedback evidence, and focus groups with candidates, mentor teachers, faculty, and school partners.
- Review Area 3, "Quality of Performance Management and Continuous Improvement," is rated from program data systems, quality-control checkpoints, monitoring practice, and partnership evidence.

Every review area receives a rating. Depending on the framework version, the report may also rate each criterion; some earlier reports discuss every criterion without stating a separate rating for it. Performance Levels are defined as follows, in language drawn from the Arkansas Literacy Review Framework:

PERFORMANCE LEVEL	WHAT THE RATING MEANS
4 — EXCEEDS	Coursework and training CONSISTENTLY address the characteristics of high-quality instruction.
3 — MEETS	Coursework and training USUALLY address the characteristics of high-quality instruction.
2 — APPROACHING	Coursework and training INCONSISTENTLY address the characteristics of high-quality instruction.
1 — BELOW	Coursework and training RARELY OR DO NOT address the characteristics of high-quality instruction.

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REVIEW AREA PERFORMANCE LEVELS		
REVIEW AREA 1 LITERACY COURSEWORK	REVIEW AREA 2 FIELD-BASED EXPERIENCES	REVIEW AREA 3 PERFORMANCE MANAGEMENT
MEETS	MEETS	MEETS
CRITERIA REVIEWED		
9	11	7

PROGRAM INFORMATION

INSTITUTION NAME	University of Arkansas - Fort Smith
LOCATION	Fort Smith, Arkansas
PROGRAM REVIEWED	Bachelor of Science in elementary education, grades K-6, delivered through three semester-long hubs and a 16-week internship; Hub 3 is not part of this review
PATHWAY	Traditional
REVIEW FRAMEWORK	TPI-US Arkansas SOR Review Framework (2024)
REVIEWING BODY	Teacher Prep Inspection-US (TPI-US)
SITE VISIT DATES	Not reported

REVIEW AREA 1: QUALITY OF LITERACY COURSEWORK

REVIEW AREA 1 PERFORMANCE LEVEL	
MEETS 9 criteria reviewed	
CRITERION PERFORMANCE LEVELS	
Overview of the science of reading	Exceeds
Concepts of print instruction	Meets
Collaborative communication, oral language instruction	Below
Phonological and phonemic awareness instruction	Exceeds
Phonics, orthography, automatic word recognition instruction	Exceeds
Fluency instruction	Exceeds
Vocabulary instruction	Meets
Text comprehension instruction	Meets
Writing instruction	Meets
WHAT THE REVIEWERS FOUND	
Reviewers examined course syllabi, live course meetings and course materials for READ 33043 Foundations of Teaching Reading and Writing, READ 35043 Methods and Materials for Teaching Literacy, READ 38043 Literacy Assessment and Intervention, and SPED 30093 Teaching Diverse Learners. Four criteria exceeded expectations: overview of the science of reading, phonological and phonemic awareness instruction, phonics, orthography and automatic word recognition instruction, and fluency instruction. Reviewers observed candidates referencing Scarborough's Reading Rope, the Simple View of Reading, Ehri's phases of word reading and the Four-Part Processing Model during class meetings, and found coursework embedded in Alma School District and Van Buren School District classrooms where candidates planned and taught with HQIM such as UFLI, Foundations and HMM Into Reading. Concepts of print, vocabulary, text comprehension and writing instruction met expectations. Oral language instruction was rated below expectations because pragmatics and discourse are not systematically taught in READ 33043, and instructors confirmed that oral language is not a designated focus in READ 35043 or READ 38043.	
REVIEW RECOMMENDATIONS	
• Strengthen instruction in oral language by preparing candidates to teach and assess the complete range of language structures, including phonology, morphology, semantics, syntax, pragmatics, discourse and orthography, and to apply those structures across every literacy component • Create an explicit, systematic spiraled scope and sequence for oral language that builds depth of content knowledge, moves to faculty modeling, provides guided practice through peer rehearsal and micro-teaching, and culminates in performance-based checks with structured feedback • Increase readiness to teach multilingual learners by studying how print concepts, syntax, semantics and syllable structures differ across languages, modeling and practicing work with cognates and idioms, and requiring fieldwork that produces performance-based evidence of differentiation	

REVIEW AREA 2: QUALITY OF FIELD-BASED EXPERIENCES

REVIEW AREA 2 PERFORMANCE LEVEL	
MEETS 11 criteria reviewed	
CRITERION PERFORMANCE LEVELS	
Selection of clinical placement schools	Meets
Selection of cooperating teachers (mentor teachers)	Approaching
Opportunities to observe models of effective early literacy practice	Exceeds
Field-based placements provide opportunities to use HQIM	Meets
Responsibilities build to candidate readiness for full responsibility	Exceeds
Opportunities to apply learning about multilingual children	Meets
Opportunities to apply learning about students who experience difficulty reading	Meets
Mentor teachers are skillful and can coach candidates	Approaching
Faculty and supervisors guide and evaluate candidates through training	Below
Quality of written and oral feedback	Approaching
Student engagement and candidate impact on student learning	Meets
WHAT THE REVIEWERS FOUND	
Reviewers examined the elementary placement tracker, memoranda of understanding, the HQIM Strategic Plan and completed Aspiring Teacher Rubrics, co-observed candidate teaching with site coordinators and mentor teachers, and interviewed candidates, mentors, principals and program leadership. Candidates' opportunities to observe models of effective early literacy practice exceeded expectations, as did the way responsibilities across Hubs 1 through 3 and the 16-week internship build toward full responsibility. Five criteria met expectations, including selection of clinical placement schools in the Alma, Van Buren and Fort Smith school districts. Selection of cooperating teachers, mentor skill in coaching literacy practice, and the quality of written and oral feedback were approaching, because science of reading criteria are not verified in mentor selection. Training for faculty, supervisors and mentors was rated below expectations.	
REVIEW RECOMMENDATIONS	
• Implement a structured, recurring training and calibration cycle for faculty, site supervisors and mentor teachers, including an annual joint scoring session on the Aspiring Teacher Rubric and a debrief of scoring variances to reach consensus and raise inter-rater reliability • Host semiannual mentor teacher training on the recently created mentor observation form covering its purpose, scoring anchors, evidence capture, feedback writing and documentation expectations • Codify a systemwide observation-to-feedback cycle with uniform procedures for advance lesson plan review, complete scoring of the required rubric domains, and agreed turnaround times for written and verbal feedback	

REVIEW AREA 3: QUALITY OF PERFORMANCE MANAGEMENT AND CONTINUOUS IMPROVEMENT

REVIEW AREA 3 PERFORMANCE LEVEL	
MEETS 7 criteria reviewed	
CRITERION PERFORMANCE LEVELS	
Quality of data the program collects and uses	Meets
Internal quality control gates (or checkpoints) and intervention plans	Meets
Quality of monitoring	Meets
Monitoring coursework quality, teaching quality, and clinical connections	Meets
Quality improvement planning	Meets
Partnerships improve candidate experiences with HQIM	Meets
Evaluation of partnerships for readiness to teach early literacy	Approaching
WHAT THE REVIEWERS FOUND	
Reviewers examined governance meeting documents, hub pre- and post-assessments, disposition evaluations, Aspiring Teacher Rubric scores, Foundations of Reading Test results, graduate and employer surveys, Contracts for Improved Performance and the program's HQIM strategic implementation plan. Six of the seven criteria met expectations: quality of data, internal quality control gates, quality of monitoring, monitoring of coursework quality and clinical connections, quality improvement planning, and partnerships that give candidates opportunities to use HQIM. Reviewers found that checkpoints such as grades, dispositions, licensure progress and rubric-scored observations trigger Contracts for Improved Performance, that faculty completed 700 hours of professional development, and that governance meetings with the Alma, Van Buren and Fort Smith school districts support two-way data review. Consistent evaluation of partnerships was rated approaching because memoranda of understanding do not codify measurable expectations such as HQIM access and mentor HQIM expertise, and completed rubrics and routine mentor feedback are gathered inconsistently.	
REVIEW RECOMMENDATIONS	
• Establish a systemwide partnership framework with districts that codifies a shared vision of high-quality placements, jointly identifies program and district needs, shares data to assess and improve the partnership, and commits both parties to clear, reciprocal responsibilities • Convert governance meetings into collaborative work sessions where brief joint needs assessments set measurable goals, supported by explicit data-flow routines covering owners, cadence and artifacts to track progress • Define the hallmarks of a strong early literacy partnership, including literacy-specific mentor selection and required training, calibrated coaching and observation cycles, timely evidence-tagged feedback, and shared outcome metrics reviewed regularly to drive continuous improvement • Embed literacy-specific, measurable requirements in district memoranda of understanding, such as mentor teacher qualifications, required use of HQIM, participation in calibration and training, data-sharing expectations, and feedback turnaround timelines	

Sources: TPI-US Arkansas Literacy Review, University of Arkansas - Fort Smith, conducted under the TPI-US Arkansas SOR Review Framework (2024). Rating scale language quoted from the Arkansas Literacy Review Framework.